

PSYC1003

Dissociation & Dissociative Identity Disorder

Part 1: What do we mean by dissociation?

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Acknowledgement of Country



We acknowledge the tradition
of custodianship & law of the
Country on which the
University of Sydney
campuses stand. We pay our
respects to those who have
cared & continue to care for
Country



Readings (non-assessable)

- Boag, S. (2025). *Dissociation & the Dynamics of Personality* (chapter 1).
- Dalenberg, CJ et al. (2012). Evaluation of the evidence for the trauma & fantasy models of dissociation. *Psychological Bulletin*, 138, 550-589
- Lynn, SJ et al. (2014). The trauma model of dissociation: Inconvenient truths & stubborn fictions. Comment on Dalenberg et al. *Psychological Bulletin*, 140, 896-910
- Dalenberg, CJ et al. (2014). Reality versus fantasy: Reply to Lynn et al. *Psychological Bulletin*, 140, 911-920

Exam Qs based on lecture material

Outline for Parts 1-3

Part 1. Introduction:

- What do we mean by dissociation & Dissociative Identity Disorder?

Part 2. Is DID real?

- Theories of DID
- Trauma model
- Sociocognitive/Fantasy model of DID

Part 3. DID & culture

- Possession states & DID



Learning outcomes (Parts 1-3)

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Describe what is meant by dissociation & the features of Dissociative Identity Disorder (DID)
- Describe & critically evaluate both the trauma & sociocognitive/fantasy models of DID
- Describe the relevance of possession states for understanding DID cross-culturally



1. Introduction

How plausible is the concept of multiple personalities within a single person (*Dissociative Identity Disorder*)?

- Believers, non-believers & agnostics
- My recommendation: Keep an open mind!



"Today you are You,
that is truer than true.
There is no one alive
who is Youer than
You." - Dr. Seuss

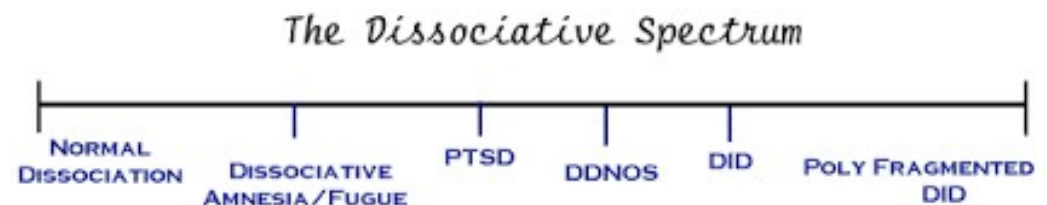




What do we mean by dissociation?

Dissociation = disconnection/separation

- Common-to-rare types of dissociation
- eg. Daydreaming ↔ DID
- “... instead of attending to a boring speaker, your eyes glaze over & your mind shifts to a favourite activity, such as sailing, creating a fantasy about the given event” (Bowins, 2004)



A-DES item

1. I get so wrapped up in watching TV, reading, or playing video games that I don't have any idea what's going on around me.

2. I get back tests or homework that I don't remember doing.

3. I have strong feelings that don't seem like they are mine.

4. I can do something really well one time and then I can't do it at all another time.

5. People tell me I do or say things that I don't remember doing or saying.

6. I feel like I'm in a fog or spaced out and things around me seem unreal.

7. I get confused about whether I have done something or only thought about doing it.

8. I look at the clock and realize that time has gone by and I can't remember what happened.

9. I hear voices in my head that are not mine.

10. When I am somewhere that I don't want to be, I can go away in my mind.

11. I am so good at lying and acting that I believe it myself.

12. I catch myself "waking up" in the middle of doing something.

13. I don't recognize myself in the mirror.

14. I find myself going somewhere or doing something and I don't know why.

15. I find myself someplace and don't remember how I got there.

16. I have thoughts that don't really seem to belong to me.

17. I find that I can make physical pain go away.

18. I can't figure out if things really happened or if I only dreamed or thought about them.

19. I find myself doing something that I know is wrong, even when I really don't want to do it.

20. People tell me that I sometimes act so differently that I seem like a different person.

21. It feels like there are walls inside my mind.

22. I find writings, drawings, or letters that I must have done but I can't remember doing.

23. Something inside of me seems to make me do things that I don't want to do.

24. I find that I can't tell whether I am just remembering something or if it is actually happening to me.

25. I find myself standing outside of my body, watching myself as if I were another person.

26. My relationships with my family and friends change suddenly and I don't know why.

27. I feel like my past is a puzzle and some of the pieces are missing.

28. I get so wrapped up in my toys or stuffed animals that they seem alive.

29. I feel like there are different people inside of me.

30. My body feels as if it doesn't belong to me.

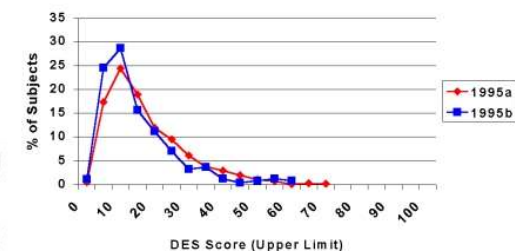
How dissociative are you?

Try the
Dissociative Experiences Scale
to find out

<http://traumadissociation.com/des>

Dissociative Experiences Scale

Valdiserri & Kihlstrom (1995a, 1995b)



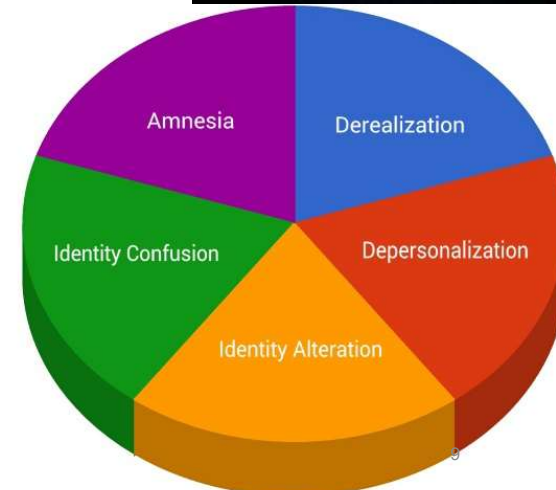


Dissociative phenomena

- *Depersonalisation*: “experiences of unreality or detachment from one’s self”
- *Derealisation*: “experiences of unreality or detachment from one’s surroundings”
- *Dissociative amnesia*
- *Dissociative fugue* (amnesia + travel)
- *Dissociative Identity Disorder*



A woman with a rare dissociative amnesia woke up thinking she was a teenager again. Here's her story [bbc.in/1a1WSC4](https://www.bbc.com/news/health-1a1WSC4)



28-year old male final year medical student. He was declared missing for 10 days prior to presentation because his whereabouts was unknown. He later arrived at his brother's house, a distance of about 634km from where he lived & schooled. The patient had no knowledge of how he made the journey that takes approximately 8 hours by road. He equally could not remember where he slept the night he left, how he raised money for the journey or the buses & routes he took. The patient denied all memory of events for the 2 days from when he left to the time he suddenly realized he was at his brother's house, 634km away. The brother, however, reported that the patient appeared unkempt, looked exhausted but was fully conscious & alert on arrival at his house without any assistance. Prior to this episode, the patient had been under severe economic & academic pressures

- Igwe, M. N. (2013). Dissociative fugue symptoms in a 28-year-old male Nigerian medical student: a case report. *Journal of Medical Case Report*, 7, 143-146¹⁰



Dissociative Identity Disorder

Formerly known as *Multiple Personality Disorder (MPD)*

- “... the presence of **two or more personality or identity states** that recurrently take control over the body”
(Pica, 1999)
- “The core phenomenon is **switches of executive control** b/w different dissociated identities with varying degrees of amnesia b/w identities” (Ross, 2011)



MPD → DID

DSM-III (1980): Recognition of MPD as a stand-alone condition

- Existence of “two or more distinct personalities”

DSM-IV (1994): *Dissociative Identity Disorder*

- “The presence of two or more distinct identities or personality states (each with its own relatively enduring pattern of perceiving, relating to, & thinking about the environment & the self”)





Dissociative Identity Disorder

DSM-5 (2013)

Diagnostic Criteria

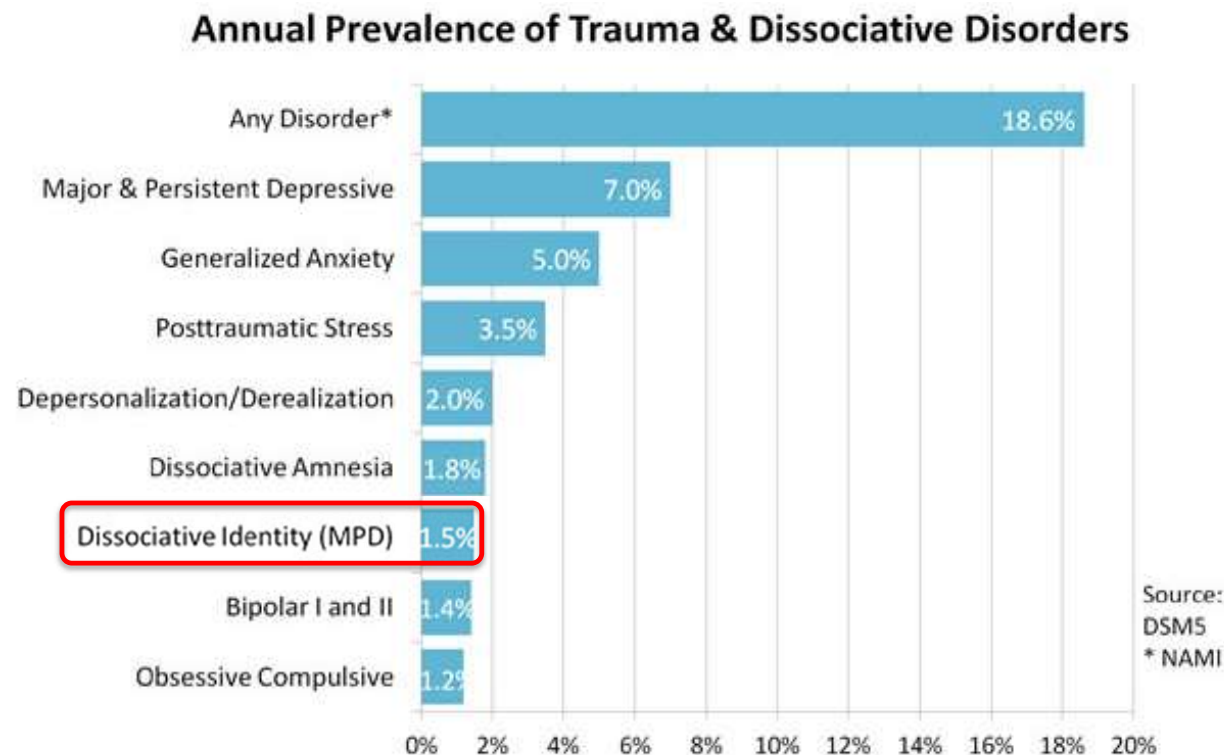
(F44.81)

- A. Disruption of identity characterized by two or more distinct personality states, which may be described in some cultures as an experience of possession. The disruption in identity involves marked discontinuity in sense of self and sense of agency, accompanied by related alterations in affect, behavior, consciousness, memory, perception, cognition, and/or sensory-motor functioning. These signs and symptoms may be observed by others or reported by the individual.
- B. Recurrent gaps in the recall of everyday events, important personal information, and/or traumatic events that are inconsistent with ordinary forgetting.
- C. The symptoms cause clinically significant distress or impairment in social, occupational, or other important areas of functioning.
- D. The disturbance is not a normal part of a broadly accepted cultural or religious practice.
- Note:** In children, the symptoms are not better explained by imaginary playmates or other fantasy play.
- E. The symptoms are not attributable to the physiological effects of a substance (e.g., blackouts or chaotic behavior during alcohol intoxication) or another medical condition (e.g., complex partial seizures).



DID prevalence

- The 12-month prevalence of DID is c.1.5%





DID: DSM-5

- **Adults: F > M** more common in clinical settings (not in childhood); males tend to deny symptoms & trauma history
- **Major depression** co-occurrence common
- **>70% DID attempt suicide**, multiple attempts common, other self-injurious behaviour
- Complicated by *dissociative amnesia*
- Misdiagnosis with **Bipolar Disorder** common



Phenomenology

- **‘Host’ personality:** typically the ‘person’ who presents for treatment, bears the legal name & suffers time-loss & psychological complaints
- **Alters or sub-personalities:** childlike personalities, protectors, helpers-advisors, guardians, inner persecutors, deviant/criminal, avengers, defenders
- **Typical DID:** 2-15 alters
- **Polyfragmented DID:**
- 100-1000+ personalities/fragments





Personalities & personality fragments

“... personality fragments are easily distinguished from full-blown personalities, because the fragments lack a life history &/or do not have a wide range of mood or affect. Complete personalities have both a history & a range of affect, as well as a consistent, ongoing style of speech & motor behaviour. New fragments may appear during therapy, but they typically appear only for limited time & purposes, they do not pose a problem for the progress of therapy, for they are easily reintegrated”
(Braun, 1984)



DID & amnesia

Dissociative amnesia (Criterion B) manifests in:

- 1) gaps in any aspect of autobiographical memory (eg. getting married)
- 2) lapses in memory of recent events or well-learned skills (eg. how to cook or drive)
- 3) discovery of possessions that the individual has no recollection of ever owning
- Each personality may have unique memories
- Any personality may or may not be aware of the other personalities



Case histories

- **Sybil:** Developed 16 separate personalities as a response to sustained childhood abuse from her schizophrenic mother
- **Billy Milligan:** 24 distinct personalities
- Severe childhood trauma
- First (successful) use of MPD for insanity defense (rape/armed robberies)
- Rogue alters committed the crimes without the others knowing about it
- **The big question: Is DID real?**

